

Child Health

You monitor the growth of every child under five, check vaccinations, and refer sick and malnourished children. You do not give curative treatment.

For health workers

Key messages

- At home visits, check the Child Health Record Book. If a vaccine is missed, ask why, explain that vaccines are safe, effective and free, and offer to go with the family.
- Vitamin A is given every six months from 6 months, and deworming from 12 months. Encourage multiple micronutrient powder for children 6 months to 5 years where available.
- Growth monitoring: use the MUAC tape on children. Below 11.5 cm (red) is severe wasting. Yellow also needs referral. Swelling of both feet is a danger sign. Refer all of these.

- Counsel on feeding: only breast milk to 6 months. From 6 to 23 months children should eat at least five of the eight food groups each day, and from 12 months about five times a day.
- Mild cough, diarrhoea and fever can be managed at home. Continue breastfeeding, give extra fluids, and keep the child fed. Refer when there is a danger sign.
- Mild vaccine side effects, such as a sore arm or fever, go away in 1 to 2 days. Refer if worse after 2 days. Trouble breathing, swelling of face or throat, bad rash all over, or fits need the health centre immediately.
- Support positive parenting: eye contact, smiles, cuddles and praise. Help caregivers notice hunger, illness and distress. Encourage parenting without violence.
- Work with the ward health committee to find solutions to barriers such as distance, cost and fear of hospitals.

Refer at once if a child has

- Fast breathing (50 or more breaths a minute at 2 to 12 months), chest indrawing, or cough for 14 days or more
- Diarrhoea for 14 days or more, blood in the stool, or signs of dehydration
- Fever for 7 days or more, or with fits, or a stiff, unconscious or hard to wake child
- Not able to drink or breastfeed, or vomits everything
- Red or yellow MUAC, or swelling of both feet
- Newborn: not feeding, floppy, too hot or too cold, yellow skin in the first day, pus in the eyes for 2 days, or fits

Run a village session

1. Meet in a shaded, central place at a time when families can come. Greet everyone and say what today's topic is.
2. Ask what people already know and what they have heard. Listen first.
3. Share three key messages from this page in your local language. Use pictures

and real examples from the village.

4. Ask people to say the messages back in their own words, and answer questions.
5. Agree on one action the village will take this month. Refer anyone who is unwell, and record who came.

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines. Based on the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.